

Battered Fish

Vodka and rice flour suppress gluten. Beer + double-leavening lifts the lace. The dredge welds it to the fish. Cold batter into 185°C oil, the fillet held submerged for 5 seconds before release.

Yield: 4 fillets Active: 35 min Total: 1 hr 15 Oil: 185°C (365°F) Internal: 60–63°C

INGREDIENTS

METRIC · VOLUME IN RIGHT COLUMN

THE FISH

White fish fillets, skinless, ≥ 2.5 cm (cod / haddock / pollock / hake, MSC)	720–800g	×	4
Brine: cold water	1 L		1 qt
Brine: fine sea salt (3% × 15 min)	30g		2 tbsp

THE DREDGE (THE WELD)

Plain flour	80g		⅔ cup
Fine sea salt	3g		½ tsp
Cracked black pepper	1g		¼ tsp

THE BATTER (MIX AT THE LAST SECOND)

Plain flour	100g		¾ c+
Rice flour (non-negotiable)	50g		⅓ cup
Cornflour	20g		2½ tbsp
Baking powder	4g		1 tsp
Baking soda	2g		½ tsp
Fine sea salt	3g		½ tsp
Lager, fridge-cold	200g		~200 ml
Vodka, freezer-cold (Heston's trick)	50g		50 ml

OIL & SERVICE

Peanut or rice bran oil (8 cm depth, 4 L pot)	2–2.5 L	—
Maldon · lemon · tartare · malt vinegar	—	—

Kit: 4 L heavy pot or Dutch oven · clipped probe thermometer (±2°C) · spider/skimmer · wire rack over tray (never paper towels) · two shallow bowls.

METHOD

- Brine** fillets in 1 L water + 30g salt — **exactly 15 min**. Lift, dry triple paper-towel, hold uncovered on a rack in fridge.

3% brine seasons through and tightens surface proteins. Wet fish = batter slides off. — Nosrat 2017
- Heat oil to 185°C** in a 4 L pot, 8 cm depth. Clipped probe thermometer.

< 170°C: batter absorbs oil before set — greasy. > 195°C: crust browns before fish cooks. — Kenji 2014
- Whisk dredge** in one bowl. **Whisk batter dries** in a second. Beer in fridge, vodka in freezer.
- At 185°C: pour cold beer + freezer vodka into batter dries. **Whisk 10–15 strokes only** — rice-grain lumps fine. Use immediately.

Gluten forms the moment flour meets water; CO&sub2; leaves the moment beer is open. Rested 10 min = half-deflated. — Heston 2006
- Dredge** fillet in seasoned flour (thin coat). **Batter**, lift by tail, drip 2–3 sec.
- Lower head-first; hold tail submerged 5–8 sec before releasing**. Sets the crust uniformly, prevents sticking.

Drop and release = sinks, sticks, tears. The single most important hand-skill. — Kenji 2014
- 2 fillets max per batch**. Fry **5–7 min** for a 2.5–3 cm fillet, turn at 3 min. Done at uniform deep gold + audibly crackles + fish reads **60–63°C**.

More than two crashes oil below 165°C; greasy fish.
- Drain 5 sec above pot**, transfer straight to wire rack. Never paper towels. Never foil.

Paper traps steam, softens underside in 90 sec. Wire rack lets steam escape from all sides.
- Salt with Maldon within 5 sec** of leaving oil, from 20 cm height. Salt bonds to hot oily crust in the first 5 sec only.
- Hold in 90°C oven** on rack, uncovered, between batches (max 10 min). Don't stack. Serve on warm plates with lemon, tartare, malt vinegar.

Done: Uniform deep gold · crust audibly crackles when tapped with the spider · internal **60–63°C** (140–145°F). No double-fry: that's for chips, not fish.

ELEVATION

TIER 1 — NO EXTRA TIME

- Rice bran oil swap** — cleaner crust, higher smoke point
- ½ tsp turmeric in dredge** — subtle golden hue
- 25% beef dripping in oil** — northern English depth
- Black pepper in batter** — 1g coarse in dries

TIER 2 — WORTH IT

- Homemade tartare** — mayo + cornichons + capers + shallot
- Mushy peas** — marrowfat soaked overnight, mint, butter
- Triple-cooked chips** — Heston's potato
- Lager-pickled shallots** — chip-shop tradition, 24 hr ahead

TIER 3 — RESTAURANT

- Goujons / fish bites** — 3 cm strips, 90 sec fry
- Tempura direction** — sparkling water, 70% rice flour
- Sourdough discard in batter** — tang + tighter crust
- Charred lemon wedges** — halved, dry-skillet 3 min

TROUBLESHOOT

Soggy crust	Oil cold / overcrowded / drained on paper. 2 fillets max, rack only.
Greasy batter	Oil < 170°C / overmixed. Hold 185°C, 10–15 strokes.
Batter slid off	Wet fish / no dredge / drop from height. Pat dry, dredge, lower at surface.
Pale crust	Oil under temp / no baking soda. 185°C non-negotiable.
Burnt outside, raw inside	Oil > 200°C / fillet too thick. Drop to 185°C; butterfly > 3 cm.
Crisp then soggy	Held in foil / stacked. Wire rack, 90°C oven, uncovered.
Tastes flat	Skipped brine / salted at plate. Brine 15 min, salt at rack within 5 sec.
Tough, dry fish	Internal > 65°C. Probe to 60–63°C max.

CHARTER PREP & STORAGE

Pre-portion dry batter	175g vacuum bags = 4 fillets each. 1 month pantry.
At service	Tip bag in bowl, add cold beer + freezer vodka, fry. 90 sec mise.
Vodka	200ml lives in freezer permanently. Sorbets too.
Frozen fish	Pollock IQF: thaw 24 hr fridge, brine as fresh.
Tartare sauce	5 days fridge sealed jar. Improves overnight.
Never fry underway	Hot oil + motion = fire. In port only. Oil disposal: shore.
Don't freeze cooked	Soggy inside, tough outside. Fry to order. No exceptions.
Scaling	Always small batter batches — CO&sub2; dies past 16 fillets.